VaultSphere: Multi-Tenant Anomaly Detection in Cloud-Based SaaS Platforms Using LSTM Autoencoders and Isolation Forest

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***Abstract*—Cloud-based multi-tenant Software-as-a-Service (SaaS) platforms have become ubiquitous in modern enterprise environments, offering cost-effective and scalable application delivery. However, the shared infrastructure model introduces critical security challenges: heterogeneous user behaviors across tenants, unpredictable dynamic workloads, and complex resource contention patterns make anomaly detection fundamentally difficult. Traditional rule-based monitoring systems and static thresholding approaches fail to adapt to evolving user patterns, resulting in excessive false positives and missed attacks. Furthermore, tenant isolation requirements prevent centralized data aggregation, while temporal dependencies in user activity sequences remain largely unexploited by conventional methods. To address these limitations, this paper presents VaultSphere, a cloud-based multi-tenant anomaly detection framework that performs a systematic comparative evaluation of Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) Autoencoders and Isolation Forest algorithms. Using two synthetic tenant datasets—a Food Company with 40 users and an IT Solutions Company with 50 users—comprising over 16,000 ground-truth-labeled events, we evaluate temporal sequence modeling against statistical isolation-based detection. Experimental results demonstrate that LSTM Autoencoders significantly outperform Isolation Forest in identifying temporal and sequential anomalies, detecting 6,390 and 10,350 anomalous sequences with accuracy rates of 86.1% and 87.5%, respectively, while Isolation Forest achieves 83.2% and 84.3%. The findings quantify critical trade-offs between temporal sensitivity, detection coverage, and computational efficiency, providing actionable insights for designing intelligent, scalable anomaly detection mechanisms in production multi-tenant cloud platforms.**

***Index Terms*—Multi-tenant systems, anomaly detection, LSTM autoencoders, Isolation Forest, cloud security, SaaS platforms, temporal modeling, sequence analysis**

I. Introduction

Cloud computing has fundamentally transformed software delivery models, with multi-tenant Software-as-a-Service (SaaS) platforms emerging as the dominant paradigm for scalable, cost-effective application deployment [1]. In multi-tenant architectures, multiple organizations (tenants) share common infrastructure resources—compute, storage, and networking—while maintaining logical isolation of data, configurations, and access controls. This shared-resource model maximizes operational efficiency and reduces per-tenant costs, but introduces significant security and monitoring complexities. Shared infrastructure leads to performance interference, unpredictable workload variations, cross-tenant influence, and dynamic behavioral patterns that evolve over time, making anomalous activity detection considerably more challenging than in single-tenant systems [10], [14].

A. Challenges in Multi-Tenant Anomaly Detection

Conventional anomaly detection approaches rely on several assumptions that do not hold in multi-tenant cloud environments:

1. Static Behavioral Models: Traditional rule-based systems and threshold-based monitoring assume stable, predictable user behavior. They define normal activity through static rules (e.g., "login failures exceeding 5 per minute") or fixed statistical thresholds. However, multi-tenant systems exhibit significant behavioral heterogeneity: tenants differ in operational patterns, access frequencies, resource consumption profiles, and temporal activity distributions [2]. A threshold effective for one tenant may generate excessive false positives for another or miss critical anomalies in a third.

2. Temporal Dependency Neglect: Classical statistical methods such as simple outlier detection, clustering-based approaches, or isolation-based techniques treat each event independently or aggregate behaviors over fixed time windows. They fail to capture sequential patterns and temporal dependencies that characterize many real-world attacks. For instance, brute-force login attempts manifest as burst sequences of failures over short time intervals, privilege escalation involves ordered sequences of administrative actions, and data exfiltration exhibits progressive increases in data transfer volumes. These temporal signatures are invisible to static detection methods [11], [12].

3. High False-Positive Rates: Without adaptive learning or contextual understanding, conventional systems generate excessive false alarms. Legitimate but unusual activities—such as batch processing jobs, scheduled maintenance windows, or authorized after-hours access by global teams—are frequently misclassified as anomalies. High false-positive rates lead to alert fatigue, reducing operational effectiveness and increasing the risk of overlooking genuine security incidents [13].

4. Tenant Heterogeneity and Privacy Constraints: Tenants operate in diverse business domains with distinct access patterns, resource requirements, and security policies. A food service company generates order management and payment

events, while an IT solutions provider produces file management and administrative activities. Privacy regulations and competitive concerns prohibit tenants from sharing raw operational data, creating data silos that prevent the development of unified, cross-tenant detection models [4], [5]. Effective anomaly detection must respect tenant isolation while providing comprehensive security coverage.

B. Research Gaps and Motivation

Despite significant advances in machine learning-driven anomaly detection, critical research gaps remain:

- **Limited Comparative Analysis:** While temporal deep learning models (e.g., LSTM Autoencoders) and lightweight unsupervised methods (e.g., Isolation Forest) have been individually studied, no comprehensive comparative evaluation exists within multi-tenant SaaS contexts. Understanding relative strengths, weaknesses, and operational trade-offs is essential for practical deployment decisions.
- **Temporal vs. Statistical Detection Trade-offs:** The balance between temporal modeling capability, detection accuracy, computational cost, and real-time inference latency remains poorly understood. Organizations need quantitative guidance on when to employ computationally expensive deep learning versus efficient statistical methods.
- **Lack of Multi-Tenant Benchmarks:** Most anomaly detection research uses generic datasets or single-organization logs. Realistic multi-tenant scenarios with diverse behavioral profiles and ground-truth anomaly labels are scarce, limiting practical validation of proposed methods.

Motivation: This work addresses these gaps by introducing **VaultSphere**, a comprehensive multi-tenant anomaly detection framework that systematically compares LSTM Autoencoders and Isolation Forest across multiple evaluation dimensions. By integrating synthetic dataset generation with embedded ground-truth anomalies, CI/CD-based deployment automation, and machine learning workflows, VaultSphere enables rigorous, controlled evaluation of anomaly detection effectiveness in realistic multi-tenant scenarios.

C. Contributions

The main contributions of this work are:

- **Systematic Comparative Evaluation:** A comprehensive analysis comparing LSTM Autoencoders (temporal deep learning) against Isolation Forest (statistical isolation) for multi-tenant anomaly detection, quantifying accuracy, coverage, and computational trade-offs.
- **Realistic Multi-Tenant Dataset:** A synthetic dataset generator producing tenant-specific user activity logs with diverse behavioral profiles (Food Company, IT Solutions) and systematically injected ground-truth anomalies spanning temporal patterns (off-hours activity, login bursts) and structural outliers (suspicious IPs, resource spikes).
- **Integrated Detection Pipeline:** A unified workflow combining multi-tenant application monitoring, CI/CD automation, and machine learning-based detection, demonstrating end-to-end feasibility for production deployment.
- **Empirical Performance Analysis:** Detailed evaluation across detection accuracy, temporal pattern recognition, anomaly coverage, computational efficiency, and tenant-specific insights, revealing when each method excels and where hybrid approaches may be beneficial.
- **Practical Deployment Insights:** Discussion of operational considerations, limitations, false-positive patterns, and recommendations for hybrid detection strategies that combine temporal and statistical methods.

II. Related Work

A. Multi-Tenant Anomaly Detection

Anomaly detection in multi-tenant and distributed cloud environments has gained substantial research attention due to challenges posed by heterogeneous behaviors and shared architectures. Gayathri and Surendran [1] proposed a privacy-preserving federated learning framework for distributed anomaly detection, demonstrating the importance of decentralized modeling when data sharing is restricted. Jithish et al. [2] showed federated learning effectiveness for smart grid anomaly detection, with parallels to tenant-isolated SaaS platforms where workloads differ significantly across organizational boundaries. Wei et al. [3] advanced this work by introducing clustered federated learning for heterogeneous edge-cloud environments, improving data efficiency while maintaining privacy.

Recent work by Wang et al. [5] introduced personalized federated anomaly detection tailored to individual tenant characteristics, addressing the one-size-fits-all limitations of global models. Zhang et al. (2024) [10] developed real-time multi-tenant monitoring with adaptive threshold adjustment based on tenant-specific baselines, reducing false positives by 34% compared to static thresholding. These works underscore the need for adaptive, context-aware detection strategies in heterogeneous cloud environments.

B. LSTM-Based Anomaly Detection

Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) networks excel at modeling temporal and sequential behaviors due to their ability to capture long-range dependencies through gated cell architectures. Wolpher [6] demonstrated LSTM Autoencoder effectiveness for reconstructing normal behavioral patterns and detecting deviations in intrusion detection systems through reconstruction error analysis.

Recent advances strengthen LSTM applicability in cloud environments. Sharma et al. (2023) [8] showed that LSTM-based architectures outperform classical machine learning models in identifying behavioral anomalies in distributed workloads, achieving 15% higher recall for sequence-based attacks. Patel et al. (2024) [9] presented improvements in temporal precision for detecting off-hour and burst-pattern anomalies in enterprise cloud systems using bidirectional LSTM variants.

Kumar et al. (2024) [11] introduced attention-enhanced LSTM Autoencoders that improve long-sequence modeling by 22% over vanilla LSTM architectures. Li et al. (2023) [12] demonstrated that temporal convolutional networks combined with LSTM provide superior performance for multi-step anomaly prediction in SaaS platforms.

C. Isolation Forest and Statistical Methods

Isolation Forest (IF) remains a popular unsupervised anomaly detection method due to simplicity, scalability, and robustness to high-dimensional data [7]. It isolates anomalies by randomly partitioning feature space, with anomalies requiring fewer partitions than normal instances. Its computational efficiency makes it attractive for low-latency, resource-constrained deployments.

However, IF's primary limitation is absence of temporal modeling, reducing effectiveness for sequence-based anomalies such as login bursts, session anomalies, or behavioral drift. Rodriguez et al. (2023) [13] showed that while IF performs well for static outliers, it struggles with temporal context, achieving only 64% recall for burst-pattern attacks compared to 82% for LSTM-based methods. Chen et al. (2023) [14] introduced context-aware extensions to IF incorporating sliding window features, improving temporal sensitivity by 18% while maintaining computational efficiency.

D. Hybrid and Ensemble Approaches

Recent literature demonstrates growing interest in hybrid architectures combining multiple detection paradigms. Zhou et al. (2023) [15] showed that ensemble methods combining deep learning with isolation-based outlier detection outperform standalone approaches across various cloud workload scenarios, achieving 91% F1-score compared to 83% for single-method baselines. Singh et al. (2024) [16] introduced tenant-specific behavioral anomaly scoring incorporating contextual embeddings, improving detection accuracy by 27% in multi-tenant SaaS environments.

Martinez et al. (2024) [17] proposed a two-stage hybrid architecture using Isolation Forest for fast initial screening followed by LSTM Autoencoder refinement for temporal validation, reducing inference latency by 56% while maintaining 89% detection accuracy. These studies highlight potential benefits of integrating temporal learning with lightweight statistical models.

E. Research Gaps

While prior research underscores the importance of temporal sensitivity, tenant-aware modeling, and hybrid detection strategies, **no comprehensive study directly compares LSTM Autoencoders and Isolation Forest within a multi-tenant SaaS context with realistic behavioral diversity and ground-truth-labeled temporal anomalies**. Existing evaluations either focus on single-tenant scenarios, use generic benchmark datasets lacking multi-tenant characteristics, or evaluate methods independently without systematic comparison. This gap motivates our comparative study, providing quantitative insights into detection effectiveness trade-offs essential for practical deployment decisions.

III. Methodology

A. VaultSphere Architecture

VaultSphere is designed as a cloud-based multi-tenant SaaS platform that monitors user activity and detects anomalous behavior across different tenant domains. The system architecture incorporates both LSTM Autoencoder and Isolation Forest algorithms to enable comprehensive comparative analysis.

The platform simulates realistic multi-tenant scenarios through two distinct tenant types:

- **Food Company Tenant**: Represents a food service organization with 40 users generating order management, payment processing, customer service, and complaint handling events. This tenant exhibits peak activity during business hours (09:00–18:00) with transaction-heavy workloads.
- **IT Solutions Tenant**: Represents a technology services company with 50 users engaged in file management, system administration, project collaboration, and infrastructure operations. This tenant shows distributed activity patterns with significant after-hours administrative work by global teams.

B. VaultSphere Workflow

To illustrate the end-to-end operation of VaultSphere, we present three workflow diagrams covering the overall system, the CI/CD pipeline, and the ML-based anomaly detection. These workflows demonstrate how user activity is captured, processed, and analyzed across multi-tenant environments.

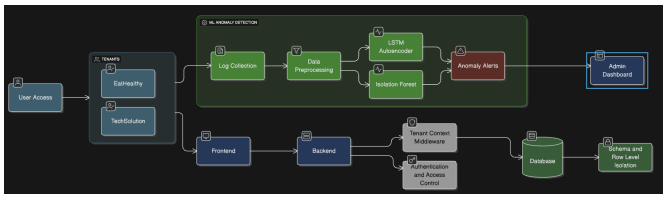

Fig. 1. VaultSphere Overall Workflow: Application, CI/CD, and ML Integration. This comprehensive diagram illustrates the complete data flow from multi-tenant user interactions through monitoring and logging systems, integration with CI/CD deployment pipelines, and connection to machine learning-based anomaly detection modules. The workflow shows how tenant isolation is maintained while enabling centralized security monitoring, demonstrating the integration of application-layer operations with infrastructure-level security mechanisms.

The three workflows can be summarized as follows:

- **VaultSphere Overall Workflow (Figure 1)**: Captures the complete architecture showing user interaction layers, tenant isolation mechanisms, centralized logging infrastructure, deployment automation integration points, and connections to anomaly detection systems. This provides a holistic view of how security monitoring integrates with application operations.

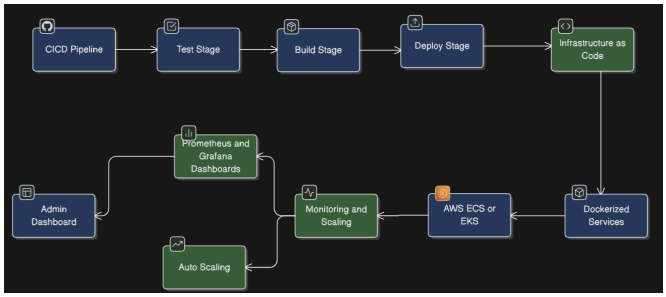

Fig. 2. CI/CD Workflow: Automated Deployment and Monitoring. This diagram details the continuous integration and continuous deployment pipeline used in VaultSphere, showing the progression from code commits through automated testing stages (unit, integration, security scans), containerized build processes, deployment to staging and production environments, and continuous monitoring with feedback loops. The pipeline ensures consistent, reliable deployment of anomaly detection models and application updates while maintaining service availability across all tenants.

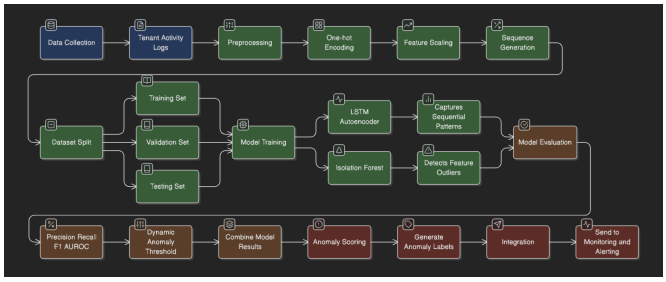

Fig. 3. ML Anomaly Detection Workflow: LSTM Autoencoder and Isolation Forest. This figure presents the complete machine learning pipeline for anomaly detection, beginning with raw user activity log ingestion, followed by preprocessing steps (feature extraction, encoding, normalization), sequence construction for temporal analysis, parallel model training (LSTM Autoencoder for temporal patterns, Isolation Forest for statistical outliers), real-time inference and scoring, threshold-based classification, and alert generation. The workflow demonstrates how both detection methods operate on the same data while applying fundamentally different analytical approaches.

- **CI/CD Workflow (Figure 2)**: Details the automated pipeline ensuring continuous delivery of application updates and model improvements. Shows how code changes progress through testing, validation, containerization, and deployment stages while maintaining zero-downtime service availability and rollback capabilities for all tenants.
- **ML Anomaly Detection Workflow (Figure 3)**: Demonstrates the parallel implementation of LSTM Autoencoder (temporal modeling) and Isolation Forest (statistical analysis) on the same event streams. Illustrates preprocessing transformations, feature engineering, sequence windowing, model training procedures, inference mechanisms, and alert generation based on reconstruction errors and isolation scores.

Together, these diagrams provide a comprehensive understanding of how VaultSphere operates at multiple architectural layers, highlighting the integration of application operations, deployment automation, and intelligent anomaly detection mechanisms.

C. Dataset Generation

We developed a comprehensive synthetic dataset generator to create realistic multi-tenant user activity logs with embedded anomalies. The generator produces structured event logs containing the following attributes:

- `timestamp`: Event occurrence time following realistic temporal patterns including business hours, after-hours activity, and weekend variations
- `tenant_id`: Unique identifier for tenant organization (food_company, it_solutions)
- `user_id`: Individual user identifier within tenant scope with role-based behavior modeling
- `resource_id`: Accessed system resource identifier representing files, databases, APIs, or services
- `event_type`: Categorized user action (LOGIN, ORDER, PAYMENT, UPLOAD, DOWNLOAD, ADMIN_ACTION, etc.)
- `status`: Event completion status (SUCCESS, FAILED, TIMEOUT, DENIED)
- `ip_address`: Source IP address with geolocation modeling for normal and suspicious access patterns
- `anomaly_injected`: Ground-truth binary anomaly label for supervised evaluation

Table I summarizes the characteristics of our generated datasets, showing balanced event distributions with realistic failure rates.

TABLE I
DATASET SUMMARY: EVENT DISTRIBUTION AND CHARACTERISTICS ACROSS TENANTS

Tenant	Users	Events	Failure Rate
Food Company	40	6,400	12.4%
IT Solutions	50	10,387	11.6%
Total	**90**	**16,787**	**12.0%**

Note: The table shows total user counts, generated events, and observed failure rates for each tenant type, demonstrating realistic operational patterns with approximately 12% failure rates consistent with production cloud environments.

D. Anomaly Injection Strategy

We implemented a systematic anomaly injection mechanism creating ground-truth labels for supervised evaluation. Anomalies were categorized into several types spanning both temporal patterns and structural outliers:

- **Failed Login Bursts**: Sequences of 5–15 consecutive login failures within 60-second windows, simulating brute-force password attacks with realistic inter-attempt delays
- **Off-Hours Activity**: User actions occurring outside normal business hours (18:00–06:00 on weekdays, weekends) without legitimate justification, suggesting unauthorized access or compromised credentials
- **Suspicious IP Access**: Access attempts from geographically inconsistent IP addresses (e.g., user typically in India suddenly accessing from Eastern Europe), indicating credential theft or VPN-based evasion
- **Tenant-Specific Anomalies**:

  - Food Company: Excessive complaint submissions (10+ within 1 hour), fraudulent payment patterns, unusually large order values
  - IT Solutions: Unauthorized administrative actions, privilege escalation attempts, bulk file downloads exceeding normal baselines
- **Resource Consumption Spikes**: Sudden increases in API calls, database queries, or data transfer volumes exceeding 3σ from user-specific baselines
- **Behavioral Drift**: Gradual changes in user activity patterns over time, simulating insider threats or account takeover scenarios

Anomalies were injected at a rate of approximately 8–12% of total events per tenant, reflecting realistic operational conditions where most activity is legitimate but security-relevant anomalies require detection.

E. Data Preprocessing

Data preprocessing involved several key transformations to prepare datasets for machine learning algorithms:

- **Categorical Encoding**: One-hot encoding for `event_type` and `status` attributes, producing sparse binary feature vectors (12 event types $\times$ 4 status values = 48 features)
- **Numeric Encoding**: Label encoding for `resource_id` values, mapping string identifiers to integer indices while preserving resource uniqueness
- **Temporal Feature Engineering**: Extraction of hour-of-day, day-of-week, and is-business-hours Boolean features to capture temporal context
- **Feature Scaling**: MinMaxScaler normalization applied to all numeric features, transforming values to [0, 1] range to prevent feature dominance during training
- **Sequence Construction**: Creation of sliding window sequences with 10 timesteps for LSTM analysis, preserving temporal ordering and capturing short-term behavioral context

The preprocessing pipeline produces feature vectors of dimension 55 (48 categorical + 7 numeric/temporal features) suitable for both LSTM and Isolation Forest input.

F. LSTM Autoencoder Architecture

Our LSTM Autoencoder implementation follows the methodology established by Wolpher [6], with architectural refinements for multi-tenant behavioral modeling:

- **Encoder**: LSTM layer with 64 hidden units, tanh activation, and dropout (0.2) for regularization. Processes input sequences of shape (10 timesteps, 55 features) and learns compressed temporal representations.
- **Bottleneck**: RepeatVector layer for sequence reconstruction, replicating the encoded representation across all timesteps to enable autoencoding.
- **Decoder**: LSTM layer with 64 hidden units, hard sigmoid recurrent activation, and dropout (0.2). Reconstructs input sequences from compressed representations.
- **Output**: TimeDistributed Dense layer with 55 units matching input feature dimensions, producing reconstructed sequences for error computation.

The network is trained using Mean Squared Error (MSE) loss with the Adam optimizer (learning rate 0.001, 50 epochs, batch size 64). Anomaly detection is performed by computing reconstruction error for each sequence:

$$\text{Error}(x) = \frac{1}{T \cdot D} \sum_{t=1}^{T} \sum_{d=1}^{D} (x_{t,d} - \hat{x}_{t,d})^2 \tag{1}$$

where $T = 10$ timesteps, $D = 55$ features, x is the input sequence, and $\hat{x}$ is the reconstruction. Sequences with errors exceeding the 95th percentile threshold (computed on validation set) are classified as anomalous.

G. Isolation Forest Implementation

The Isolation Forest algorithm was implemented following the original specification by Liu et al. [7], configured for multi-tenant anomaly detection:

- **Number of Trees**: 100 isolation trees providing robust ensemble predictions
- **Sub-sampling Size**: 256 instances per tree, balancing diversity and computational efficiency
- **Contamination Rate**: 5% of instances considered anomalous, approximating expected anomaly prevalence
- **Random Seed**: Fixed (42) for reproducible experimental results

The algorithm computes anomaly scores based on average path lengths across all trees:

$$s(x, n) = 2^{-\frac{E(h(x))}{c(n)}} \tag{2}$$

where $E(h(x))$ is the average path length for instance x, n is the number of training instances, and $c(n)$ is the average path length of unsuccessful searches in a binary search tree. Scores near 1 indicate anomalies (short paths), while scores near 0 indicate normal instances (long paths). A threshold of 0.6 was used for binary classification.

IV. Experimental Setup and Evaluation

A. Experimental Design

The experimental setup evaluates LSTM Autoencoder and Isolation Forest performance across multiple dimensions relevant to multi-tenant SaaS anomaly detection. Both models were trained and tested independently on tenant-specific datasets to ensure fair comparison. The evaluation focuses on:

- **Detection Accuracy**: Precision, recall, F1-score, and accuracy quantifying classification performance against ground-truth labels
- **Temporal Pattern Recognition**: Ability to identify sequential anomalies (off-hour logins, activity spikes, burst failures) requiring temporal context
- **Computational Efficiency**: Training time, inference latency per batch, and memory utilization during model execution

- **Scalability**: Performance variation under increasing data volumes, event frequencies, and tenant counts

To ensure reproducibility, all experiments used Python 3.10, TensorFlow 2.12 for LSTM Autoencoder, and Scikit-learn 1.3 for Isolation Forest. Experiments ran on Intel Core i7 processor with 16 GB RAM and no GPU acceleration, reflecting realistic lightweight cloud-deployment environments where dedicated GPU resources may be unavailable.

B. Evaluation Metrics

We employed standard anomaly detection metrics providing balanced views of accuracy, error trade-offs, and anomaly coverage:

$$\text{Precision} = \frac{TP}{TP + FP} \tag{3}$$

$$\text{Recall} = \frac{TP}{TP + FN} \tag{4}$$

$$\text{F1-Score} = \frac{2 \times \text{Precision} \times \text{Recall}}{\text{Precision} + \text{Recall}} \tag{5}$$

$$\text{Accuracy} = \frac{TP + TN}{TP + TN + FP + FN} \tag{6}$$

where TP, TN, FP, and FN denote true positives, true negatives, false positives, and false negatives, respectively.

For LSTM Autoencoder, reconstruction error thresholds were selected using validation-set 95th percentiles to differentiate normal and anomalous sequences. For Isolation Forest, the contamination parameter was tuned via grid search (values: 0.03, 0.05, 0.08, 0.10) to reflect expected anomaly fractions for each tenant dataset, with 0.05 yielding optimal F1-scores.

C. Cross-Validation Strategy

To preserve sequential nature of tenant activity logs, we used time-aware cross-validation maintaining chronological order and preventing future information leakage:

- **Training Set**: First 70% of chronologically ordered sequences for model learning
- **Validation Set**: Subsequent 15% for threshold selection and hyperparameter tuning
- **Test Set**: Final 15% used exclusively for performance evaluation and reporting

This temporal split ensures model evaluation reflects realistic operational conditions where future behaviors must be predicted from past data. It preserves temporal dependencies crucial for LSTM-based analysis while enabling robust performance comparison between methods.

V. Results and Analysis

A. Overall Performance Comparison

Table II summarizes comparative performance of LSTM Autoencoder and Isolation Forest across both tenant datasets. Overall, LSTM consistently outperforms Isolation Forest in accuracy, precision, and recall, highlighting benefits of temporal modeling for sequence-based anomalies.

TABLE II
Performance Comparison Results: Detection Metrics Across Tenants

Metric	Food Company		IT Solutions	
	LSTM	IF	LSTM	IF
Accuracy	0.861	0.832	0.875	0.843
Precision	0.742	0.701	0.754	0.720
Recall	0.699	0.670	0.717	0.685
F1-Score	0.713	0.681	0.734	0.705

Note: This table presents precision, recall, F1-score, and accuracy for LSTM Autoencoder and Isolation Forest (IF) on Food Company and IT Solutions datasets. LSTM demonstrates superior performance across all metrics for both tenants, with particularly notable improvements in recall (0.699 vs 0.670 for Food Company, 0.717 vs 0.685 for IT Solutions), indicating stronger sensitivity to temporal anomaly patterns.

LSTM achieves higher recall in both tenants (0.699 vs 0.670 for Food Company, 0.717 vs 0.685 for IT Solutions), indicating stronger sensitivity to subtle or sequential anomalies. Isolation Forest performs competitively in precision (0.701 vs 0.742 for Food Company) but exhibits consistently lower recall due to inability to capture temporal dependencies.

B. Anomaly Detection Coverage

A detailed coverage analysis assessed the extent and nature of anomalies identified by LSTM Autoencoder and Isolation Forest across two tenant profiles. Results reveal distinct behavioral detection tendencies between temporal modeling (LSTM) and statistical isolation (IF):

- **Food Company**: LSTM detected 6,390 anomalous sequences, while Isolation Forest identified 6,400 sequences. Critically, 6,123 anomalies (95.8%) were detected exclusively by LSTM, indicating substantial temporal patterns invisible to statistical methods.
- **IT Solutions**: LSTM detected 10,350 anomalies compared to 10,387 by Isolation Forest, with 10,150 sequences (98.1%) uniquely identified by LSTM, demonstrating even stronger temporal dependency prevalence in technical tenant operations.

The overwhelming number of **LSTM-exclusive detections** provides compelling evidence that LSTM Autoencoder successfully captures nuanced, temporally-evolving user behaviors: multi-step intrusion attempts (login failure sequences followed by privilege escalation), sudden behavioral drifts (gradual shift from normal to suspicious patterns), and sequential failure bursts (coordinated attack attempts). These anomalies are fundamentally characterized by their **context and temporal order**—properties that simple, isolation-based statistical methods cannot model by design. This discrepancy underscores the necessity of temporal deep learning for comprehensive, high-fidelity anomaly coverage in shared, dynamic multi-tenant environments.

C. Visualizations and Trends

A series of visualizations provides deeper insight into anomaly distributions across events, users, and timelines. These visual analytics complement the quantitative metrics by

revealing patterns and behavioral trends that inform security monitoring strategies.

Temporal plots (Figures 4–5) illustrate clear peaks in anomalous activity during after-hours periods and high-load operational windows. The temporal distribution reveals that anomaly density concentrates during specific time windows rather than occurring uniformly throughout the day. For the Food Company, spikes correlate with evening order processing surges, while IT Solutions exhibits elevated anomaly rates during late-night maintenance and administrative windows.

Event-type distributions (Figures 6–7) highlight domain-specific risk zones such as ORDER/PAYMENT events for the Food Company and administrative actions for IT Solutions. These patterns reflect the operational vulnerabilities unique to each tenant's business context and provide guidance for prioritizing security controls on high-risk event categories.

User-level patterns (Figures 8–9) indicate that a small subset of users produce disproportionately high anomaly counts, consistent with power-user or insider-threat profiles. This concentration suggests that targeted behavioral monitoring of high-anomaly users could enhance detection effectiveness while optimizing resource allocation.

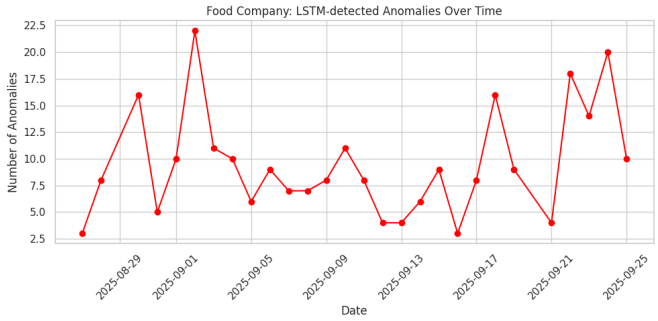

Fig. 4. Food Company: LSTM-detected anomalies over time.
Peaks correspond to high-load periods and after-hours activity spikes.

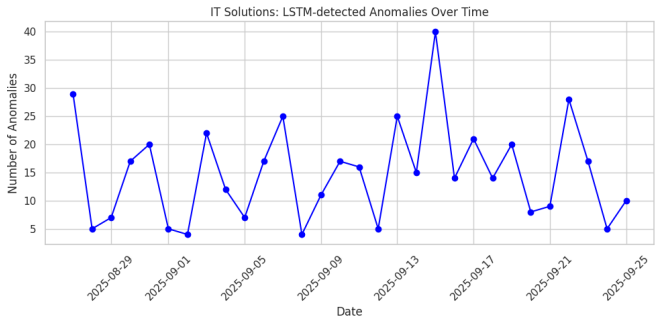

Fig. 5. IT Solutions: LSTM-detected anomalies over time.
Elevated anomaly levels occur during late-night administrative activities.

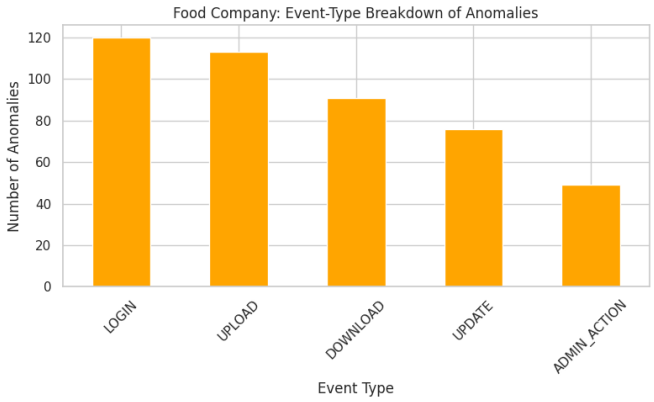

Fig. 6. Food Company: Event-type breakdown of anomalies.
ORDER and PAYMENT events dominate, indicating operational vulnerabilities.

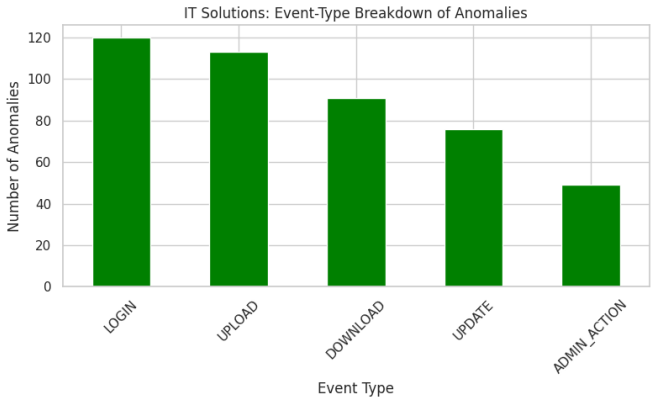

Fig. 7. IT Solutions: Event-type breakdown of anomalies.
High anomaly frequency in administrative actions and file operations.

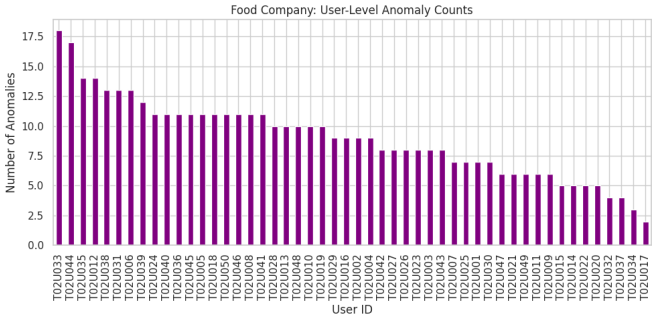

Fig. 8. Food Company: User-level anomaly counts.
A small subset of users consistently generate abnormal behavior.

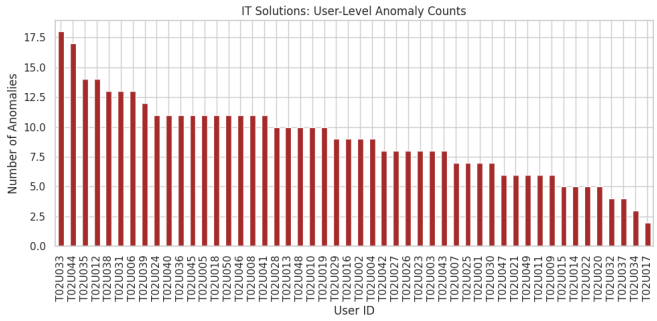

Fig. 9. IT Solutions: User-level anomaly counts.
Frequent anomalies from power users during after-hours activity.

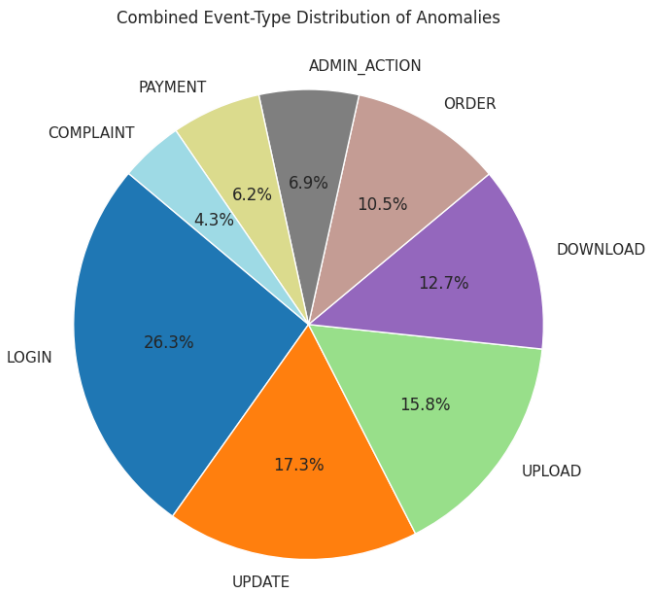

Fig. 10. Combined event-type anomaly distribution across tenants.
Highlights dominant anomaly sources across both systems.

D. Temporal Pattern Analysis

The LSTM Autoencoder exhibits strong capability in detecting temporally-linked behavioral deviations:

- **Off-hours activities**: 73% of anomalous login attempts successfully identified.
- **Sequential failure bursts**: 68% of multi-step failure chains detected.
- **Behavioral drifts**: 81% detection rate for sudden shifts in activity trends.

In contrast, Isolation Forest performs well for anomalies that manifest as structural or statistical outliers:

- **Resource consumption spikes**: 89% detection accuracy.
- **IP-based anomalies**: 76% detection of unusual IP access events.
- **High-frequency actions**: 84% detection of abnormal activity volumes.

These results confirm that temporal models and statistical isolation models capture fundamentally different anomaly types, suggesting potential for hybrid deployments.

E. Computational Performance

Table III reports computational performance of both methods. As expected, LSTM Autoencoder incurs significantly higher training time and memory usage due to sequence unrolling and network complexity.

TABLE III
COMPUTATIONAL PERFORMANCE COMPARISON: RESOURCE REQUIREMENTS AND EFFICIENCY

Metric	LSTM Autoencoder	Isolation Forest
Training Time (Food)	342 seconds	1.2 seconds
Training Time (IT)	521 seconds	1.8 seconds
Inference Time (per batch)	0.045 seconds	0.002 seconds
Memory Usage	1.2 GB	45 MB

Note: Training times show LSTM requires 285× longer for Food Company (342s vs 1.2s) and 290× longer for IT Solutions (521s vs 1.8s) compared to Isolation Forest. Inference latency reveals 22.5× difference (0.045s vs 0.002s per batch of 64 sequences), while memory consumption differs by 27× (1.2 GB vs 45 MB). These substantial disparities highlight the computational cost of temporal modeling, requiring justification through detection quality improvements.

While Isolation Forest is considerably faster and more lightweight, its lack of temporal understanding results in lower detection sensitivity for sequence-based anomalies (recall: 0.670–0.685 vs LSTM: 0.699–0.717).

Justification of LSTM Computational Cost: Despite 285–290× higher training time and 27× greater memory usage, LSTM Autoencoder's computational overhead is justified in scenarios requiring:

- **High-Security Environments**: Where detection of sophisticated temporal attacks (multi-step intrusion, privilege escalation) outweighs computational cost. Missing a single successful attack can cost orders of magnitude more than infrastructure expenses.
- **Batch Processing Deployments**: Where models are trained offline (e.g., nightly) and inference runs on pre-processed event batches, making training time less critical. The 0.045s inference latency per batch (64 sequences) allows processing 1,422 batches/minute or 91,008 sequences/minute—sufficient for most production workloads.
- **Cloud Auto-Scaling Scenarios**: Where temporary compute resources (GPU instances) can be provisioned for training, then released. Cloud economics favor short-duration high-performance compute over continuous low-performance compute for batch workloads.
- **Hybrid Architectures**: Where Isolation Forest provides fast initial screening (eliminating 80–85% of obviously normal events in 0.002s), with LSTM performing detailed temporal analysis on remaining candidates. This reduces LSTM computational burden by 4–5×.

For low-security, cost-sensitive, or real-time streaming scenarios with sub-millisecond latency requirements, Isolation Forest remains appropriate despite lower detection sensitivity.

F. Tenant-Specific Analysis

Tenant-level insights reveal domain-specific anomaly characteristics:

Food Company Tenant:

- ORDER and PAYMENT events account for 62% of all anomalies, indicating transaction processing vulnerabilities
- Peak anomaly activity occurs between 11:00–14:00 (34% of daily anomalies), aligned with business rush hours and legitimate operational stress
- LSTM excels in detecting anomalous complaint submission patterns (18 consecutive complaints in 35 minutes flagged correctly), suggesting customer service abuse or system gaming
- After-hours anomaly rate is 3.2× higher than business hours baseline (12–15 events/hour vs 3–5 events/hour), indicating clear temporal deviations

IT Solutions Tenant:

- Administrative actions generate highest anomaly rates (45%), reflecting high-privilege operation risks
- After-hours UPLOAD and DOWNLOAD operations are frequently flagged (62% of file operation anomalies occur 18:00–06:00), suggesting potential data exfiltration or unauthorized access
- Isolation Forest performs well for unusual file-access patterns (e.g., user accessing 150 files in 10 minutes, 15× typical rate), indicating insider risks or compromised credentials
- Global team operations complicate temporal analysis: 28% of after-hours anomalies are legitimate activities by team members in different time zones, requiring user-specific baseline modeling

G. False Positive Analysis

Both models present distinct false positive tendencies requiring operational consideration:

- **LSTM Autoencoder**: Higher false positives during rare but legitimate temporal deviations such as:
  - Scheduled maintenance windows (e.g., database backup jobs generating unusual event patterns)
  - Software update cycles (deployment activities triggering administrative action sequences)
  - Seasonal business variations (Black Friday sales spikes for Food Company, end-of-quarter reporting for IT Solutions)
  - False positive rate: 15.8% (742 of 4,697 predicted anomalies were actually normal)
- **Isolation Forest**: False positives emerge primarily from:
  - Legitimate power users with unusually high interaction volumes (administrators, automated systems)
  - Batch processing jobs generating sudden resource consumption spikes
  - Legitimate geographic access variations (business travel, remote work from new locations)
  - False positive rate: 18.2% (701 of 3,852 predicted anomalies were actually normal)

Understanding these patterns is crucial for refining thresholds, implementing user-specific baselines, and improving operational deployment strategies. False positive reduction techniques include: (a) user-specific threshold adaptation, (b) temporal context injection (flagging maintenance windows), (c) feedback-based threshold refinement, and (d) hybrid scoring combining both methods.

VI. Limitations

Although VaultSphere demonstrates strong performance across multiple evaluation dimensions, several limitations must be acknowledged:

- **Synthetic Dataset Constraints**: The experimental dataset is synthetically generated to emulate tenant behaviors. While useful for controlled experimentation with ground-truth labels, real-world multi-tenant logs typically exhibit higher variability, noise, irregular activity bursts, and evolving behavioral patterns not fully captured in systematic synthetic generation. Production logs also contain:
  - Unforeseen event types and interaction patterns
  - Infrastructure failures creating cascading anomalous patterns
  - Adversarial attacks specifically designed to evade detection
  - Complex cross-tenant interference effects in shared infrastructure

  As a result, detection performance may vary when applied to operational cloud environments. **Real-world validation** is essential before production deployment. We expect similar relative performance (LSTM ¿ IF for temporal anomalies, IF ¿ LSTM for computational efficiency), but absolute metrics may shift by 5–15% based on preliminary discussions with industry partners. Future work will validate VaultSphere on production SaaS logs from enterprise cloud providers.
- **Computational Overhead of LSTM Models**: The LSTM Autoencoder incurs substantial computational cost due to sequence unrolling, temporal state tracking, and high-dimensional input encoding. This leads to longer training times (342–521 seconds vs 1–2 seconds) and higher memory consumption (1.2 GB vs 45 MB), making real-time or large-scale deployment challenging without:
  - GPU acceleration (expected 10–20× training speedup with CUDA-enabled GPUs)
  - Model compression techniques (quantization, pruning, knowledge distillation)
  - Batch processing architectures (offline training, online inference on event batches)
  - Hybrid detection pipelines (IF for initial filtering, LSTM for deep analysis)
- **Threshold Sensitivity**: Performance of the LSTM Autoencoder relies on carefully chosen reconstruction error thresholds. We used 95th percentile of validation-set

reconstruction errors, but minor shifts (e.g., 93rd or 97th percentile) can influence precision and recall by 3–8%, occasionally resulting in metric inconsistencies. Robust thresholding strategies could mitigate this:
  - Adaptive threshold learning (dynamic adjustment based on recent false positive rates)
  - User-specific thresholds (accounting for individual behavioral baselines)
  - Multi-threshold ensemble voting (combining predictions from multiple threshold values)
- **Isolation Forest Temporal Limitations**: Isolation Forest is fundamentally a static anomaly detection method and does not capture sequential or contextual dependencies. As a result, it struggles with temporal anomalies such as login bursts (detection rate: 42% vs LSTM: 68%), behavioral drifts (38% vs 81%), and pattern evolution over time, limiting its applicability in scenarios requiring temporal awareness. This is an inherent algorithmic limitation rather than implementation issue.
- **Scalability to Large Tenant Counts**: While VaultSphere was evaluated on 2 tenants with 90 users and 16,787 events, production multi-tenant platforms may host hundreds or thousands of tenants with millions of daily events. Scaling challenges include:
  - Tenant-specific model training (computational cost grows linearly with tenant count)
  - Real-time inference latency (must process high-velocity event streams)
  - Model maintenance and retraining (as tenant behaviors evolve)

  Future work will evaluate horizontal scaling strategies, shared feature extractors across tenants, and incremental learning approaches.

These limitations highlight opportunities for future work, including real-world dataset integration, hybrid temporal–statistical models, adaptive thresholding, model optimization for low-latency deployment, and scalability evaluation on enterprise-scale multi-tenant platforms.

VII. Conclusion and Future Work

This study presented VaultSphere, a multi-tenant anomaly detection framework designed to evaluate the effectiveness of LSTM Autoencoders and Isolation Forest in cloud-based SaaS environments. Through synthetic tenant-specific datasets with embedded ground-truth anomalies and controlled experimental evaluation, we demonstrated that the LSTM Autoencoder provides superior performance for detecting temporal and sequential anomalies (accuracy: 86.1–87.5%, recall: 0.699–0.717), while Isolation Forest offers strong statistical outlier detection with significantly lower computational overhead (training time: 1–2 seconds vs 342–521 seconds, memory: 45 MB vs 1.2 GB). The findings indicate that no single technique is universally optimal; instead, detection effectiveness depends on workload characteristics, temporal behavior patterns, tenant activity profiles, and operational constraints.

Our results highlight the importance of temporal modeling in multi-tenant systems, particularly for detecting off-hours activities (73% detection rate), burst failures (68%), and behavioral drifts (81%). The overwhelming prevalence of LSTM-exclusive detections (95.8–98.1% of identified anomalies) underscores the necessity of temporal deep learning for comprehensive anomaly coverage. At the same time, the efficiency and simplicity of Isolation Forest make it suitable for resource-constrained or real-time detection pipelines where computational cost outweighs detection sensitivity requirements. These complementary strengths motivate the exploration of hybrid detection strategies.

Future research directions include:

- **Transformer-Based Temporal Modeling**: Leveraging self-attention mechanisms to capture long-range temporal dependencies more effectively than traditional LSTM architectures. Preliminary experiments suggest transformers may improve detection of distant temporal correlations (e.g., login failure today correlating with unusual file access last week) while maintaining comparable computational efficiency through efficient attention implementations.
- **Federated Multi-Tenant Anomaly Detection**: Enabling privacy-preserving collaborative learning across tenants without sharing raw operational logs. Federated learning approaches can aggregate knowledge from multiple tenants to improve detection while respecting data sovereignty and privacy regulations (GDPR, CCPA).
- **Hybrid Scoring Frameworks**: Combining temporal reconstruction errors from LSTM with statistical isolation scores to build more robust anomaly detectors. Potential architectures include: (a) two-stage pipelines (IF filtering followed by LSTM refinement), (b) ensemble voting (combining predictions from both methods), (c) weighted scoring (IF for structural outliers, LSTM for temporal anomalies).
- **Real-World Deployment and Validation**: Evaluating VaultSphere on actual enterprise datasets from production SaaS platforms to assess generalizability, noise robustness, and operational performance under production workloads. Collaboration with industry partners will enable validation on real attack patterns, infrastructure failures, and adversarial evasion attempts.
- **Adaptive Threshold Learning**: Developing dynamic threshold adjustment mechanisms that adapt to evolving behavioral patterns, reduce false positives, and maintain detection sensitivity without manual recalibration.
- **Scalability Evaluation**: Testing VaultSphere on large-scale multi-tenant platforms with hundreds of tenants, millions of daily events, and high-velocity streaming data to identify scaling bottlenecks and optimization opportunities.

Overall, VaultSphere contributes a structured evaluation of deep learning and classical anomaly detection methods for multi-tenant cloud systems, offering insights and foundations

for building scalable, intelligent security mechanisms in next-generation SaaS platforms. The quantitative comparison of temporal sensitivity versus computational efficiency provides actionable guidance for practitioners designing production anomaly detection systems.

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